Meditations

A review by Sean O'Dea

It is an unfortunate tragedy, or perhaps an innate quality of the human condition, that we live, learn, and relearn the same fundamental truths about humanity. In the words of Fernando Pessoa: "The right way to live is something we can only teach the dead," and in a similar vain Marcus Aurelius states, "He who has seen present things has seen all, both everything which has taken place from all eternity and everything which will be for time without end; for all things are of one kin and of one form," (vi.38) and "to have contemplated human life for forty years is the same as to have contemplated it for ten thousand years" (vii.49). Especially given the insanity of our present times, I've been finding solace in the wisdom of the past and amazed at how quickly we discard their revelations and ignore their warnings. After reading a text like this you look around at the social ills that inundate and vex us, and the root causes become not only simple but obvious.

I truly believe this is a book everyone should read at least once in their life, but preferably many times. Anyone deciding to read *Meditations* should go into it with a basic understanding and context of what it is. It's certainly not a long-form philosophical essay with exploratory arguments or examples, nor is it merely a personal journal, but lands somewhere in the middle as a reflective, practical workbook for living a good life, an ancient self-help book if you will. The twelve "books" the text has been divided into don't follow any kind of thematic flow and in general many of the passages are short, discursive ideas.

Originally written by the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius (last of the Five Good Emperors), it's seen as one of the most notable works of Roman Stoicism among Epictetus and Seneca who labored to keep the old Greek ideals alive. It was given the unofficial title "Meditations" for publishing as the original work was left untitled, however "Reflections" or as classicist Mary Beard refers to it, "Jottings to Himself," would perhaps be more fitting. This text was never designed for public consumption. Some have speculated that he may have written these ideas for the purpose of teaching his soon-to-be-emperor son Commodus (who obviously did not follow the virtuous example of his father), but it's very likely it was simply a collection of advice for himself to continuously reflect on as a means of gaining perspective, or simply as a reminder of first principles.

There exists equal parts irony and pertinence to the origins of *Meditations*. In one manner, Aurelius' preachings about the impermanence of fame and reputation, how

everyone will be soon forgotten in the infinitely long future, cemented him as perhaps one of the most unforgettable historical figures, and at least in the top five best-remembered Roman Emperors. But in the other manner, the book's humble opposition to such a goal, both in its context and intention to never be read by another human, make it the *perfect* candidate to advocate for those ideals.

I see this as one of the most fundamental texts to the human condition in its simplicity, practicality, relatability, and applicability. I feel any human across cultures, geography, and time period could pick up this book and not only relate a piece of their experience to it, but find some way to improve their actions or thoughts. In my own experience I found reading it to be quite calming, and I suppose meditative in a way. It's of course not going to fix your life overnight, but they're nice ideas to have floating around in your head to return to at any time.

There's little I can add to the commentary regarding Aurelius' specific ideals -- nor would I be qualified too -- so instead I'll list off some of my favorite themes. These are paraphrased in my own words.

- Humans are rational, intelligent beings by nature, and should always pursue virtue by aligning themselves with the divine reason which they share a part of.
- The nature of the universe is change. All things are simply change, including death and loss.
- The elements that constitute your body were separate for an eternity, have come together for a short time, and will again disperse for eternity. Death is merely the process of this dissolution.
- Our slice of time is infinitely miniscule and insignificant. This means that you should both cherish and make the most of the short time you're given, but also not be bothered by misfortunes or sins done to you because they are so ephemeral. It also means the pursuit of vain glory and fame after death is pointless, as all things will soon be forgotten by posterity.
- We should never expect the universe or any person to not act according to their nature. Therefore, we should not expect otherwise or be surprised at the occurrence of change, death, or when evil men commit evil acts.
- Intentionality - life should be lived intentionally, actions should be towards an end.
- The present is the only thing that truly exists at any given time. The past is gone and the future is yet to be.
- Humans are social beings by nature. We are meant to live and interact in political (social) societies. One shouldn't isolate themselves from others, as we share a common kinship both in community and in humanity as a whole.

- What is good for the whole is good for the individual. Always do things for the good of the many.
- You have no agency in the things out of your control, merely your reaction to them. If someone wrongs you, or you experience misfortune, it does not make your life or self better or worse, your reaction to it does. Therefore your happiness and growth is entirely within your control. Your mind is free, and therefore you are free.
- Bad and good things happen equally to bad and good people.
- Nature is the ordered system which governs the Universe. Nature always acts according to Reason, and was instituted by God, who is benevolent or at worse indifferent, therefore Nature cannot be evil, nor the things that adhere to it.
- One can and must examine their life through the tools of philosophy, and by doing so elevates their mind above the corporeal and its facile temptations.
- If you fail in your pursuit of virtue and right ideals, which you inevitably will, simply return to first principles, and be satisfied if the greater part of what you have done was according to your nature and your goals.
- If anyone does wrong to you, consider their state of mind and ignorance to greater principles, and either take it in stride, or teach them to be better. The greatest revenge is to not be like him who has wronged you.
- Welcome wealth, prosperity, or good fortune with open arms, but be ready to part with it at any time.
- Give little heed to what others think of you, or if they think or act as you do, as long as you are adhering to right principles.
- Love your fate, and always be content with which Nature has given you or deprived you of.
- Always pursue wisdom (the knowledge of good and evil), justice (the giving to every man his due), fortitude (the enduring of labor and pain), temperance (moderation in all things), freedom, contentment, simplicity, and modesty. These are the core tenets of a happy and virtuous life.

Like any philosophy or way of life, Stoicism has its potential pitfalls. I think if followed to an extreme it could lead to becoming detached from your emotions (good or bad depending on what you subscribe to) or becoming a stick in the mud, someone who spends too much time auditing their life for virtue instead of just living it. I also think one who relies too much on contentment may miss out on their full potential due to complacency. In general though, I don't believe these to be outcomes that Stoicism as a whole or Aurelius ever advocates for, and would likely be the result of leaning too much on any one of its core tenets. In fact, Aurelius specifically states that humans are meant to live a life of action, and that playing a part in your society is both important and necessary. I also wonder if Stoicism is a more male-centric philosophy but I currently lack any sources to argue for or against that.

Meditations has been used and revered by some of the foremost leaders in history including John Smith, Theodore Roosevelt, and Nelson Mandela, who were all said to have carried a personal copy during perilous expeditions, or in the case of Mandela, during his imprisonment. It is revered by many and has certainly built up a reputation throughout history, but I would encourage anyone to form their own opinion of it and only give it the reverence they think it's due. I would also recommend the commentary on the text as much as the text itself, as it often provides interesting insight, interpretations, historical context, and related citations. My copy came with a foreword by Pierre Baumann and the translator notes by George Long.

I look forward to revisiting Aurelius' words throughout my life as a perspective on personal growth and to use it for its intended purpose as a reminder of the fundamental truths to always return to.

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I had a sort of revelation while reading this about how it was essentially a Commonplace journal, and I'm sure he wrote his thoughts as they came to him, in whatever depth felt appropriate at the time (which accounts for why some paragraphs are a single sentence while others are pages long). This is not a commonplace book in the way that some practice it where it is strictly externally sourced reading or inspiration, but more in the way that I practice it where I write down any ideas that I find interesting, whether it be my own or something I found. I felt a sort of kinship with Aurelius in this regard, and I'd encourage anyone else to try it out if you haven't.

My other revelation came from how George Long, the translator I read, noted in his afterword that he translated the original text merely for personal use, and yet his translation became one of the most widely read. The common thread here being that things designed for personal use merely out of an individual desire are often also useful for so many others. This is a cool idea both from a practical standpoint and a more spiritual one of our mental kinship as humans, and also one especially applicable in the tech sphere. So go make that thing for yourself that you've always wanted, and someday someone might also love it just as much as you do.